

The other way is to use a sniping service. There are a variety of sniping services available.

Sneaky? Well, yes. But this technology is out there for everyone, so I'm certainly not the only one using it. I once won an auction for 99 cents, on an item that usually goes for \$20–\$25. How much does it cost to snipe an auction? Just 25 cents per snipe, and *only* if you win the auction. If you lose (and it can happen, but it's very rare), then you don't use a snipe credit. And on average, you'll save around 25–35% on every auction.

Do yourself a big favor and learn the art of sniping. It'll save you a ton of money, and you can avoid the bidding wars forever. Happy sniping.

—Paul Michael

Miss the Big Sale? Claim Your Savings Anyway

The sudden aggravation of my son's allergies became the last straw for this frugal family. While we had suffered through a summer or two in

our old farm home with little to no air-conditioning in most rooms, this year was going to be different. Credit card in hand (we enjoy collecting on those rewards points), my husband headed to our local retail store for the 12,000 BTU beauty.

Soon after he arrived, he called me from his cell phone—a bit more than aggravated. “Linsey, it’s showing \$50 more than what you said it was going to cost.” I reached for my sale ad and realized that the great price on the very last one in stock had ended—yesterday.

“Tell them you want it anyway.” I figured it couldn't hurt, right? After all, I had been reading so much on haggling lately (but never really tried it). How hard could it be?

The happy ending to my story is that I got my A/C for yesterday's sale price. We slept in two hours of dehumidified and cooled air last night (I set it on a very conservative cycle to save energy). My son woke up without his little pink eyes today (he had white ones, instead). We are very happy.

We also learned a bit about real-world haggling techniques.

1. Know the price

This is different from “Know *your* price.” Your price (what you're willing to pay) may be higher than what